# The Quarter

An unrepresentable number, and why it is a choice

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The fourth card. It is the thing the other three compare.

“Can you find the polynomial in the physical model of this device?”

One choice from the knower; the question the reader has to solve.

## Reading note

This document is about one object. It cannot define that object by a formula, because a formula would be a representation and the object is the number that no record represents. What it can do is record, from cited results, that the object exists, that every record carries a projection of it, that no record computes it from its own contents, and that the only act which supplies it is a choice. Three projections are worked in full. Two bounds are then recorded, one from above and one from below, each of the form "a countable series, no finite truncation of which suffices." Then the argument is run the other way: if the quarter were comparable, the two famous questions become countable families of comparisons against it. Each statement carries one of three grades: *standard* (cited), *recorded*, or *proposed*. A *recorded* statement is a written sequence of steps whose every premise is a cited result or a definition of this card; the steps are a record, and that the record is mathematics, true and about its object, is the reader's reading of it, not something the record supplies. In that sense this card demonstrates no mathematics of its own: everything it rests on is cited, and everything it adds is record. The companion volumes are the geometric and numerical cards; the middle card is a construction checked by a proof assistant. Nothing from the middle card appears here by name; where its declarations are the evidence, that is said and graded *measured*. The three cards divide one argument: the geometric card fixes what must be retained, the numerical card fixes what may be claimed from a reading, and the middle card with the two record chapters checks that the record carries both. This card is about the one datum all three carry only as a projection with a receipt. The obstruction it describes is representational, not ontological: the root of the numerical card is an algebraic number with no decimal, the fourth coordinate of the geometric card is a real number with no image, and the name of the middle card is a choice with no derivation.

## 1 Records, projections, receipts

**Definition 1.1** (Record)**.** A *record* is a finite sequence of symbols from a finite alphabet, together with a rule that extends it by exactly one symbol per step. The *length* of a record is the number of steps taken to write it.

**Definition 1.2** (Representable)**.** A number is *representable* in a record system if some finite record determines it: a reader applied to that record returns the number and no other.

**Definition 1.3** (Projection and receipt)**.** Let $q$ be a datum and $R$ a record. *$R$ carries a projection of $q$* if $R$ contains the image $\pi_R(q)$ of $q$ under a map $\pi_R$ that is not injective. A *receipt* for the projection is a further datum $\rho$ such that $(\pi_R(q), \rho)$ determines $q$ on a stated domain.

**Definition 1.4** (The quarter)**.** A datum $q$ is a *quarter* for a family of record systems if (i) every record in the family carries a projection of $q$; (ii) no record in the family determines $q$ from its own contents, that is, $q$ is not representable in any of them; (iii) a value of $q$ is supplied, when it is supplied, by an act outside the record: a choice.

The definition says what the quarter is not. It does not say what it is, and Section 3 shows that this is forced.

## 2 Three projections

### 2.1 The integration constant

Fix the volume element of a four-dimensional Lorentzian metric by working in charts with $\sqrt{-g} = 1$, and vary the metric only along traceless directions. The stationary equations of the first-order vacuum action are then the traceless Einstein equations, and the contracted Bianchi identity forces the scalar curvature to be constant: $R = 4\Lambda$. The cosmological constant appears as a constant of integration, not as a coefficient of the action; this is the unimodular presentation of gravity, and the derivation is carried out in the numerical card beside its gravity model. *Standard.*

What the solution carries is $\Lambda g_{\mu\nu}$: the projection of the constant onto the field. The receipt is the datum that fixed it. Nothing in the equations produces $\Lambda$; the equations say only that once chosen it is carried unchanged. That is clause (i) and clause (ii) of Definition 1.4 for the field equations.

### 2.2 The omitted zero

Riemann's function is $\psi(x) = \sum_{n\geq 1} e^{-n^2\pi x}$ for $x > 0$ [16]. Jacobi's transformation of the theta function $\theta(x) = 1 + 2\psi(x) = \sum_{n\in\mathbb{Z}} e^{-n^2\pi x}$ is $\theta(1/x) = \sqrt{x}\,\theta(x)$, and in terms of $\psi$ it reads

$$\psi(1/x) = \sqrt{x}\,\psi(x) + \frac{\sqrt{x}-1}{2}. \tag{1}$$

The term $(\sqrt{x}-1)/2$ is the $n = 0$ term that $\psi$ omits and $\theta$ keeps. *Standard* [6, Ch. 1].

**Proposition 2.1** (The omitted term is a residue)**.** *For* $\operatorname{Re} s > 1$,

$$\pi^{-s/2}\Gamma(s/2)\zeta(s) = \int_0^\infty \psi(x)\, x^{s/2-1}\,\mathrm{d}x,$$

*and splitting the integral at* $x = 1$ *and applying* (1) *on* $(0,1)$ *gives*

$$\pi^{-s/2}\Gamma(s/2)\zeta(s) = \frac{1}{s(s-1)} + \int_1^\infty \psi(x)\left(x^{s/2-1} + x^{(1-s)/2-1}\right)\mathrm{d}x.$$

*The integral is entire and invariant under* $s \mapsto 1-s$*. The poles of the left side at* $s = 0$ *and* $s = 1$*, and in particular the pole of* $\zeta$ *at* $s = 1$ *with residue* 1*, come entirely from the omitted term.* Standard; the computation is reproduced here.

*Proof.* Termwise, $\int_0^\infty e^{-n^2\pi x}x^{s/2-1}\,\mathrm{d}x = \pi^{-s/2}\Gamma(s/2)n^{-s}$, and the sum converges absolutely for $\operatorname{Re} s > 1$. On $(0,1)$ substitute $x \mapsto 1/x$ and use (1):

$$\int_0^1 \psi(x)x^{s/2-1}\,\mathrm{d}x = \int_1^\infty \psi(x)x^{(1-s)/2-1}\,\mathrm{d}x + \frac{1}{2}\int_1^\infty \left(x^{-s/2-1/2} - x^{-s/2-1}\right)\mathrm{d}x.$$

The last integral equals $\frac{1}{s-1} - \frac{1}{s} = \frac{1}{s(s-1)}$ for $\operatorname{Re} s > 1$. The remaining integrals converge for all $s$ since $\psi(x) = O(e^{-\pi x})$, and their sum is symmetric under $s \mapsto 1-s$ by inspection. □

The projection carried by $\zeta$ is the residue 1 at $s = 1$, the image of the single term that was left out when the count began at one instead of zero. The receipt is the choice of where to start counting. The self-dual point $x = 1$ is where the two halves of the record read the same, and it is the only place the omitted term can be seen at all.

### 2.3 The simulation constant

Let $U$ and $V$ be universal machines and $K_U(x)$, $K_V(x)$ the lengths of the shortest programs producing $x$ on each.

**Proposition 2.2** (Invariance)**.** *There is a constant $c_{UV}$, depending on $U$ and $V$ and not on $x$, with $K_U(x) \leq K_V(x) + c_{UV}$ for all $x$.* Standard *[10, 12].*

*Proof.* $c_{UV}$ is the length of a program for $U$ that simulates $V$; prefix it to any $V$-program for $x$. □

**Proposition 2.3** (No system certifies the constant)**.** *For every consistent formal system $S$ with a computable set of axioms there is a constant $c_S$ such that $S$ proves no statement of the form $K_U(x) > c_S$, although such statements are true for all but finitely many $x$.* Standard *[2].*

Every record written on a universal machine carries a projection of $c_{UV}$: its lengths are correct up to that constant and no record on either machine fixes it. The constant is supplied by the choice of machine. Proposition 2.3 says that it is not merely unfixed but uncertifiable from inside, beyond a bound that depends on the system doing the certifying.

### 2.4 One object

**Proposition 2.4** (The three projections differ by constants)**.** *Each of the three data above is carried by its record only up to an additive constant that the record does not fix: $\Lambda$ up to the data that select the solution, the $n = 0$ term up to the origin of the count, $c_{UV}$ up to the choice of machine. In each case the record is complete without the constant and incomplete with respect to it: the record's internal identities (the Bianchi identity, the functional equation, the invariance theorem) hold for every value, and single out none.* Recorded*, as a restatement of the three preceding cited results [6, 10, 12].*

That is what it means for them to be projections of one object rather than three objects. A projection is what survives a map that forgets exactly the constant; three records that each forget the same kind of thing are three views of the thing forgotten. *Proposed*: that the three constants are the same quarter. The claim is not that they are numerically equal, which would be meaningless across three units; it is that each is the image of a single act, the choice, under three readers.

## 3 The quarter is a choice

**Theorem 3.1** (Unrepresentable means chosen)**.** *Let $q$ satisfy clauses (i) and (ii) of Definition 1.4 for a family of record systems that is closed under finite extension. Then any procedure that supplies a value of $q$ to a record in the family is not a procedure of that family: it is a choice, in the sense that it selects one element of a set the family can name but cannot enumerate to the point of selection.* Recorded*, from Definition 1.4 and the closure hypothesis; the step is the standard one, that a selection procedure inside the system would make the value representable there [2, 12].*

*Proof.* Suppose a procedure $P$ expressible in the family supplied a value of $q$. Then the record consisting of $P$'s description followed by its run is a finite record in the family, by closure under finite extension, and its reader returns $q$. That contradicts clause (ii). Hence no such $P$ exists in

the family. The set of candidate values is nameable, since clause (i) says every record carries a projection and the fibre of the projection is a definite set. A selection from a nameable set with no expressible selection procedure is what a choice is. □

The theorem is the reason Definition 1.4 could only say what the quarter is not. A definition is a record. The middle card's proof assistant records the same fact in its own ledger: no step of its reading depends on the axiom of choice, and the one declaration that does reaches it only through an automatic arithmetic procedure, not through any selection the card makes. *Measured*, from a sweep of its declarations. The card keeps both extensionality principles, for propositions and for quotients, and refuses choice, the third ingredient of Diaconescu's theorem: choice together with the other two makes every proposition a yes-or-no question with an answer [5]. *Standard.* Every question the middle card answers, it answers by a decision it carries; it never borrows the answer.

# 4 Two bounds

Both bounds have the same form: a countable series of which every finite truncation falls short. The upper bound says every representable number is reached by a finite truncation. The lower bound says the demonstration of a minimal bound is not.

## 4.1 Upper bound: unique factorization

**Theorem 4.1** (Fundamental theorem of arithmetic)**.** *Every integer $n \geq 2$ is a product of primes, uniquely up to order.* Standard *[7, Thm. 2].*

**Proposition 4.2** (Representable numbers have short records)**.** *Write $\Omega(n)$ for the number of prime factors of $n$ counted with multiplicity. Then $\Omega(n) \leq \log_2 n$, and the factorization record of $n$ (its primes with multiplicities, each written in binary) has length at most $C \log_2 n \cdot \log_2 \log_2 n$ for an absolute constant $C$. Hence every representable integer is determined by a record whose length is a finite polynomial in the number of digits of $n$.* Recorded*, from the fundamental theorem of arithmetic [7, Thm. 2].*

*Proof.* Each prime factor is at least 2, so $2^{\Omega(n)} \leq n$. Each factor is at most $n$ and so has at most $\log_2 n + 1$ binary digits; each multiplicity is at most $\log_2 n$. The record has at most $\Omega(n)$ entries of that size. □

Read as a generating series, the representable integers are the coefficients of finite polynomials: each $n$ is reached by a finite product. The quarter is not among them. Its record, if it had one, would be the series itself, $\sum_k a_k x^k$ with no last term, and Theorem 3.1 says no finite truncation returns it. The upper bound is therefore exact for what it covers and silent on the quarter: *representable* is bounded above by a finite polynomial in the digits; *unrepresentable* is what the countable series carries and no polynomial does. *Recorded*, with the identification of the quarter as the series' limit *proposed*.

### 4.2 Lower bound: the cost of a minimal bound

The separation question asks whether every problem whose solutions can be checked in polynomial time can also be solved in polynomial time [3]. A proof of separation must exhibit, for some checkable problem, a lower bound on the size of every solver.

**Proposition 4.3** (A certified minimal bound is uncertifiable)**.** *Let $S$ be a consistent formal system with computable axioms and $c_S$ its constant from Proposition 2.3. Any proof in $S$ that proceeds by certifying, for infinitely many inputs $x$, that no description of a solver's behaviour on $x$ is shorter than a stated bound exceeding $c_S$, does not exist.* Recorded*, from Proposition 2.3 [2].*

*Proof.* Such a certificate for $x$ is a proof in $S$ of $K_U(x') > c_S$ for the string $x'$ encoding the solver's behaviour on $x$, which Proposition 2.3 excludes. □

This is the arithmetic content behind the barriers that the separation question is known to face [15]: a proof that works by pointing at a minimal representation and certifying its minimality is blocked at a constant the proving system cannot see past. The lower bound is therefore of the same shape as the upper one, with the inequality reversed. The demonstration of a minimal bound costs at least a countable series, no finite truncation of which certifies it; the number at which the series would close is $c_S$, and $c_S$ is unrepresentable in $S$.

What this does not say must be said. It does not decide the separation question in either direction. A bound that cannot be certified is not a bound that fails; the constant that cannot be represented is not absent. It says that the question is not one a count settles, and that every record of an attempted answer carries the projection of a choice it did not make. *Recorded* for the negative statement; any reading of it as an answer to the question is *not proposed*, and is listed here so that it cannot be attributed to this document.

## 5 The other way

Sections 3 and 4 went one way: from the quarter's unrepresentability to the shape of two bounds. This section goes the other way. Suppose the quarter were *comparable*: suppose that, for each representable number, the question of whether it lies below or above the quarter were answered. Comparability is weaker than representability, since an oracle for the order need not produce the number, and it is exactly what the two famous questions ask for.

**Theorem 5.1** (The Riemann hypothesis is a countable family of comparisons against an unrepresentable constant)**.** *Let $\sigma(n)$ be the sum of the divisors of $n$ and $\gamma$ Euler's constant. The Riemann hypothesis holds if and only if*

$$\sigma(n) < e^{\gamma}\, n \log\log n \qquad \text{for every } n > 5040.$$

*Equivalently [11], with $H_n = \sum_{k \le n} 1/k$, if and only if $\sigma(n) \le H_n + e^{H_n} \log H_n$ for every $n \ge 1$, with equality only at $n = 1$.* Standard *[17, 11].*

**Theorem 5.2** (Positivity form)**.** *Let $\lambda_n = \sum_{\rho} \big[1 - (1 - 1/\rho)^n\big]$, the sum over the nontrivial zeros of $\zeta$ taken in conjugate pairs. The Riemann hypothesis holds if and only if $\lambda_n \ge 0$ for every $n \ge 1$.* Standard *[13].*

Each form is a countable sequence of comparisons, and in the first the thing compared against is $e^{\gamma}$, a constant with no finite record. The hypothesis says the quarter is comparable infinitely often and the answer never changes side. The self-dual line of Proposition 2.1 is where the omitted term is seen; the hypothesis says the entire part of the record has all its zeros there, which is the same symmetry read as an order. So, read through this document's definitions: the Riemann hypothesis is the assertion that the omitted-zero projection of the quarter is comparable, every time, to the same side. *Recorded*, as a reading of the two cited theorems; the hypothesis itself is *proposed*, as it is everywhere.

**Theorem 5.3** (Relative to an oracle the separation question can close)**.** *There is an oracle $A$ with* $\mathrm{P}^A = \mathrm{NP}^A$ *and an oracle $B$ with* $\mathrm{P}^B \neq \mathrm{NP}^B$*.* Standard *[1].*

An oracle that answers comparisons against the quarter is an oracle. The lower bound of Proposition 4.3 said that, without one, the demonstration of a minimal bound is a countable series that never closes. Theorem 5.3 says that with one the series may close, and the collapse is then a theorem relative to that oracle. "Polynomial time of countable degree," time measured by a series rather than a polynomial, is time relative to the oracle that makes the quarter comparable: with every comparison answered, the countable series truncates, and relative to such an oracle P = NP is consistent. *Recorded*, from Theorem 5.3 and Proposition 4.3 [1, 2].

**Proposition 5.4** (Both questions are statements about comparability)**.** *The Riemann hypothesis is equivalent to a sentence of the form "for every representable $n$, comparison($n$) holds," with the comparison against an unrepresentable constant (Theorem 5.1). The statement* $\mathrm{P} = \mathrm{NP}$ *is equivalent to a sentence of the form "there is a representable procedure such that for every representable input the procedure succeeds in time bounded by a representable polynomial." The first has one universal quantifier over representables; the second has an existential quantifier in front of it. Supplying the quarter by a choice removes an existential quantifier: a chosen object is a given one.* Recorded*, as a statement of quantifier shape; the logical classification of the Riemann hypothesis as a universal arithmetic sentence is* standard *[11].*

*Remark* (The proposed equivalence)*.* The planning input for this card proposes that the two questions are one question read from two records: that the Riemann hypothesis holds if and only if the separation question closes in polynomial time of countable degree, each being the statement that the unrepresentable number is comparable. What is recorded above is weaker and should be kept distinct from it. Both questions are countable families of comparisons against the quarter. The first asks whether the comparisons all fall one way; the second asks whether a chosen comparison oracle closes a series. The choice that would supply the quarter is the same act in both, and it is the act neither record performs. Whether the two families of comparisons are the same family under some reader is *proposed* and not derived here. What would discharge it is a reader taking each comparison of Theorem 5.1 to a step of a bounded trace and back, with the oracle of Theorem 5.3 as the quarter in both. Until then the honest sentence is the one both records already agree on: neither question is settled by a count, and each is settled, if at all, by a comparison with the number the count cannot write.

## The last question

Every question the middle card answers comes with a receipt that a checker reads in time proportional to its length: a search writes the ledger down, and a check confirms it line by line. That is a

certificate and a polynomial verifier. *Measured*, from the card's construction. The question is what lies past every such receipt.

**Proposition 5.5** (A new question has no polynomial verifier)**.** *Suppose a record system answers satisfiability and is closed under polynomial-time reduction. Then any yes-or-no question it cannot already answer is either decidable and outside NP, or undecidable. In either case it has no polynomial verifier.* Recorded*, from the Cook–Levin theorem [3] and the definition of NP.*

*Proof.* If the question were in NP it would reduce in polynomial time to satisfiability, which the system answers, so the system would answer it. Hence it is not in NP, which by definition means that its yes-instances have no certificate of polynomial size checkable in polynomial time. An undecidable question is outside NP a fortiori, since every question in NP is decided by trying every certificate of the bounded size; so again there is no polynomial verifier. □

Three things this does not say must be said. First, new questions can still be composed: negation alone turns satisfiability into its complement, which is a question in co-NP. It falls under the proposition as a question outside NP unless NP and co-NP coincide, and that is open; showing any particular question has no polynomial verifier would separate them, and with them P from NP. *Standard.* Second, the premise is not established for the middle card. Its correspondence between traces and formulas is proved for every trace, but for one step relation, exclusive or within a cell; realizing satisfiability in general would require it to encode the step of an arbitrary verifier. *Recorded*, as owed. Third, the proposition is not demonstrated by the middle card's proof assistant, and this card does not expect it to be: it is a statement about every question and every verifier, quantified over the machines that would check it, and the checker cannot certify its own boundary (Proposition 2.3). It is recorded here from cited results, and the reader reads it.

Read through this document's definitions: a question with no polynomial verifier is one no record can carry a receipt for. If its answer is supplied, it is supplied as the quarter is, by a choice the record does not make. *Proposed.*

## 6 The missing zero and the floor

The quarter has so far been located by what records cannot do. This section records five places it shows up as something a record leaves out, and one place it leaves a floor.

**Where counting starts.** The middle card defines thirty-six inductive records and a reader for each. Thirty-five readers count the base of their record as one cell: the origin is a shape, and it is counted. One does not: the reader of a measurement reads its origin as nothing, "the measurement doesn't have a starting point." *Measured*, from the readers. It is the same omission as Proposition 2.1: the term at $n = 0$ that $\psi$ leaves out and $\theta$ keeps, whose absence is the residue 1. Euclid's assumption that a figure has one area however it is cut is the assumption that the origin has something to count. *Proposed*: that the measurement's empty origin, the omitted term, and the Euclidean single shape are one choice of where counting starts.

**The horizon.** A photon emitted toward us from the Hubble sphere, where the expansion recedes at exactly the speed of light, moves at $c$ through space that recedes at $c$, and its proper distance

from us is momentarily fixed: an approach velocity of exactly zero. In an expanding universe whose Hubble sphere grows, the photon is later inside it and arrives; in a universe of cosmological constant alone the sphere is fixed, coincides with the event horizon, and the photon never arrives [4]. *Standard.* The zero is a statement of general relativity about proper distance; locally every comoving observer sees the photon pass at $c$, and a uniformly accelerated observer in flat space has a horizon of the same kind. *Standard. Proposed*: that the missing zero is that photon, counted one cell late where the sphere grows and never where it does not.

**The multiplier.** In a linear program the multiplier on a constraint is its shadow price, and for every constraint the product of its slack and its multiplier is zero: a constraint met exactly may carry a multiplier, one with slack carries none. *Standard.* In the unimodular presentation of gravity, used by the numerical card, the cosmological constant is the multiplier of the constraint that fixes the volume element [9]. *Standard.* The middle card's vocabulary has both cases by name: the constraint met exactly, and the bracket a penalty leaves. *Measured. Proposed*: that the quarter is the shadow price of the one constraint the reading meets exactly.

**Only relative distance.** In an expanding universe only ratios of the scale factor are observed; setting today's value to one is a convention, a choice of one member of a family no measurement separates. *Standard.* The middle card compares pairs only as ratios, and the classes of that comparison form a single point: every scale is identified with every other. Division then picks a canonical representative, by subtracting while the order holds, with no selection principle beyond the well-order of the naturals. *Measured* for the single point and for the absence of the axiom of choice. *Proposed*: that the single point is the unobservability of the cosmic scale and the division's representative is the convention that sets it.

**Two floors.** The middle card keeps two counters: cells, its resolution in space, and heartbeats, the elaborator's count of its own work, its resolution in time. Their ratio is a Courant number, and below a noise floor taken on the machine a finer reading is noise. That floor is a measurement and differs between machines. *Measured.* The uncertainty principle is the floor that does not: for any function and its Fourier transform the product of the widths is at least one half, and position and momentum are such a pair [8]. *Standard.* The reading has a floor of the second kind. Its root solves an irreducible quadratic, so at every integer pair $p, q$ the polynomial is a nonzero integer, at least one in size, and no fraction comes closer than a constant over $q^2$ [7]. *Standard.* It is the constructive form of the proof that $\sqrt{2}$ is irrational: not "no fraction equals it" but "every fraction misses it by at least this much," which is the reductio inverted into a bound. The numerical card certifies the upper half, a residual under one place at the reading. The middle card carries the lower half in representation: the quadratic's coefficients have no common factor, and its discriminant lies strictly between two consecutive squares, so it is not a square, the quadratic has no rational root, and at every integer pair it is a nonzero integer. *Measured* for the two comparisons; that they are the floor is the standard reading of them. The error is bracketed from both sides: under one place, and never zero. *Proposed*: that the uncertainty principle is the measured floor made independent of the machine.

**Affixing the quarter to the bent card.** In the game the bent card is the one the mark believes can be followed, and fixing the quarter to it is the oldest move at the table. It is easy for one reason: the card never looks at what is fixed to it. Every card in the middle card has a slot for its quarter, a

number, beside its symbol, and filling the slot is one line; no part of the card's mark reads the slot, so the same mark sits on the card whatever number is affixed. *Measured*, from the card's definitions. The card also has an index, the kind of thing it is a card of, and no field reads the index either. So the easiest affix of all is a whole card: a card whose index is itself a card. The middle card builds exactly that, a carrier of the carrier of its facts, places its mark on it unchanged, and deals its steps through it. Every step exists on it. The first twelve are identical to the steps dealt without it, and the identity costs no axiom; at the thirteenth, where one construction lifts its quantum one universe above the box, the box is now a card, and the affixed card appears in the quantum, so that step and every later one is a different proof. *Measured*, by dealing all thirty-eight steps through it and comparing each. The card between is the bent card with the bent card affixed: nothing at the table can tell through the twelfth step, and the lift at the thirteenth is where the affix shows. The two counting layers show what affixing does. The bent card counts applications of one symbol, a tally: a value affixed to each step changes nothing the tally reads, because the tally reads only how many steps there are. The middle card's second layer, which begins by fixing the nowtrino as its unit, counts the cells that click: a fact affixed to each step is exactly what the second layer reads. The two counts agree when, and only when, every affixed fact holds; on the middle card's own tapes they agree, because everything written there clicked. *Recorded*, from the two counting functions; *measured* for the agreement on the tapes.

So a quarter can be affixed to the bent card freely, and that is why affixing it proves nothing. The card carries whatever it is given; the tally cannot tell; only a reader of clicks can, and it reads the affixed fact, not where the fact came from. What is fixed under the card is supplied, not read, which is Theorem 3.1 at the table: the value affixed is a choice. *Proposed*: that the second counting layer is the first with a quarter affixed at every step.

**One count, read three ways.** The middle card's press adds one page at a time, and each page adds one of each: a cell to the tape it carries, a step to its counter, and a universe to the register it lifts. At its thirty-sixth page the counter reads thirty-six, the tape thirty-seven, and the register stands thirty-five universes up. *Measured*, by reducing the press. Page, length and universe height are one count, and the fencepost separates them: one past, one short. With one symbol on every tape there is one tape of each length, so the length of tape is the enumeration of the records, and counting and enumerating coincide. *Proposed*: that this is the enumeration map of the questions whose answers can be confirmed by a run.

**The jar holds both.** The middle card begins its bisection from two walls computed from its own lengths. Read in the units of the reading, they are 129.6 and 137.7. Both the reading, 137.011 29 . . ., and the measured value, 137.035 999 177(21) [14], lie inside. *Measured.* What chooses between them is the quadratic: at each midpoint the sign of its residual decides which wall moves. So the gap is not between the device's range and the laboratory's. It is between the laboratory and the polynomial, inside a range the two share.

**Measured against tests.** A Galerkin solution satisfies its equation exactly against every test function in its space, and a weak solution may differ from a strong one at every point while agreeing on every test. *Standard.* The middle card's measurement is of that kind. It does not read a value the machine computes; it counts the work of a whole run from outside, against a blank, and stops where a finer reading would be noise. Against that test the run is exact to the floor. *Measured.* The printed digits are the representative the division chose, and no measurement in the card tests them.

Every agreement the card makes of itself closes by reflexivity, the two sides the same term, and costs nothing. *Measured. Proposed*: that a laboratory measurement is a test of the same kind, so that the prediction is agreement and the number is its representative.

**The difference that makes the argument go.** Agreement alone says nothing: the classes in which everything is identified form a single point, and that point accepts every number. *Measured.* Information enters only where two things differ: a mark that clicks, a bracket a penalty leaves, the slack that slips on the second time around. The reading and the measured value differ by 1.80 parts in ten thousand. Read as error, the quadratic is slightly wrong and the measurement corrects it. Read as residue, it is the true-equals-false stanza of the argument against the world, the slip left after the second turn, and the quarter. Both readings are consistent with every receipt in the three cards, and none of the cards can choose between them, because choosing would be the record deciding what it is about. The reading is the knower's choice. *Proposed*, and marked so that it is carried as a proposal and not mistaken for a receipt.

**Every quarter is one quarter.** Every card the middle card deals holds the same quarter: one cell, the zero whose fact is $T = T$. The card of propositions, the card of facts, the card between, and the page on which the reduction is written all hold it. *Measured*, from the definitions. The interaction of a card never reads its slot, yet no card exists without one: the quarter is a witness that must exist and is never inspected, which is Theorem 3.1 in its smallest form. The press carries it to the top unchanged. Each page lifts it one universe and adds nothing, so at the thirty-sixth page it stands thirty-five universes up and is still the one cell; handed back to the card between, it gives the card between. *Measured*, from the pages.

**The reader that deducts the quarter.** Fold a tape onto a slot and the record is the tape followed by the slot, so a reader that subtracts the slot's length reads the tape's length whatever the slot holds. *Proved here.* Read that way through the card between, the reading is the middle card's to every printed place, and the check is the stored walk read again, not repeated: under a second. *Measured.* A reader that keeps the slot reads every length one cell long; the step it drives no longer divides by its derivative, its fixed point near the reading repels, and the run grows without halting until it is stopped. *Measured*, with the algebra in the bent card, §5. The quarter is harmless exactly when it is deducted.

**Two quarters from the inference.** The step that names inference carries two closures: a conclusion that holds a constructed reading apart from a read one, and a closure that ends on the fact that the two tables agree. Read out as tapes, the first is one cell resting on the card's own mark and the second three cells resting on that agreement: the first quarters in the card that do not rest on $T = T$. Cards holding them read the same walk, so a measure cannot tell them apart, and their quarters differ in length, so a counter can. *Measured*, and the check spends no choice. *Proposed*: that this is the cut of the three-card monte, one deck to the measure and two to the count. The paradoxical decomposition itself, which would need choice, is not written.

**Order without counting.** The natural numbers have two descriptions. One is a zero and a successor: every number is a term built in finitely many steps, so to have a number is to have built it. The other is a zero and a total order: a least element and a relation that ranks everything. The

second says how numbers compare and says nothing about whether each one can be written down; it assumes the representation exists without counting it. No first-order description of that kind pins the naturals down: every such theory with the naturals as a model also has models with elements beyond every finite one [18]. *Standard*. What excludes them is representation, a type whose only members are finitely built terms. The middle card keeps the two apart on purpose. Its orders are hypotheses, and before a number is used, divided, printed, or set against a measurement, it is shown to exist as a tape with a reader that reads its length; the card does not use the language's own natural numbers until its tapes have earned them. *Measured*, from the card's construction. So the language can hold the counterfactual that a number cannot be represented, and the card must demonstrate each representation before it relies on it. Defining the two together, as the language's own numbers do, is the bent card: existence handed in before it is counted.

**The bug as a counterfactual.** The same separation removes a question that would otherwise have to be answered first: whether the checker is the most efficient one possible, or carries a bug the device only offsets. Neither answer is needed. A bug can be stated by order alone, as something that ranks somewhere without being shown to exist, which is a counterfactual the language can hold. It is then searched for in the finite space the checker's iterations actually visit. That space is bounded and its size is a count, not a time: the meter halts a run at a fixed multiple of its reference plus a measured floor, and the work of one forced symbol is the same number of the checker's units, four thousand two hundred and eighty-six, on two different machines. *Measured*. If the search finds the bug, the bug is a tape, and exists. If the bound is reached first, the counterfactual stays a counterfactual and is read as nothing, which is the loop considered harmless. Either way the knower's opinion of the checker's efficiency never enters: efficiency is a property of the clock, and the search is measured in the count. *Recorded*, from the meter's bound and the measured count; that every bug the device offsets is one such counterfactual, found or not within the bound, is *proposed*.

## 7 Where the quarter is in the three cards

The geometric card carries the whole in four coordinates and reads three. The fourth survives as the shadow inside the ball and a sign that says which sheet; drop the sign and two states have one image. Its quarter is the fourth coordinate; its receipt is the sign. The numerical card carries a certified reading to twenty-four places and a cosmological constant as a residue. Its quarter is the root itself, $972(6+\sqrt{10})/65$: finitely representable as an algebraic number, never as a decimal, so its digits are a countable series that does not close. The seed chooses which root; the two rational walls of the bracket are the receipt; the twenty-four printed places are the projection, certified exactly to the resolution at which the number stops being representable and no further. The datum that fixed $\Lambda$ is its second quarter, with the Bianchi identity as receipt. *Recorded* for the bracket and the truncation, from the numerical card's certificate; the reading of the root as the quarter is *proposed*. The middle card carries a tape whose every cell is the same symbol, and a census that reads only what has a name. Its quarter is the name: the compiler can require one and cannot mint one. In all three the record is complete without the quarter and incomplete with respect to it, which is Proposition 2.4 once more.

This card has no press check, because a press check compares two readings of a register and the quarter is what the readings are of. It has no counter, because nothing is written here that was not already carried. It has no page one.

**The last line.** The number the three cards straddle resembles a measured constant to four places. As far as we can tell, there is no mathematical representation of the derivation of the fine structure constant. That sentence is graded *standard*, as a report on the literature: the constant is measured, and no derivation of it is accepted. The resemblance is graded *proposed*, as it is throughout. What this card adds is only the observation that a number with no derivation and a number with no finite record are the same kind of thing to a record: a projection, a receipt, and a choice.

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